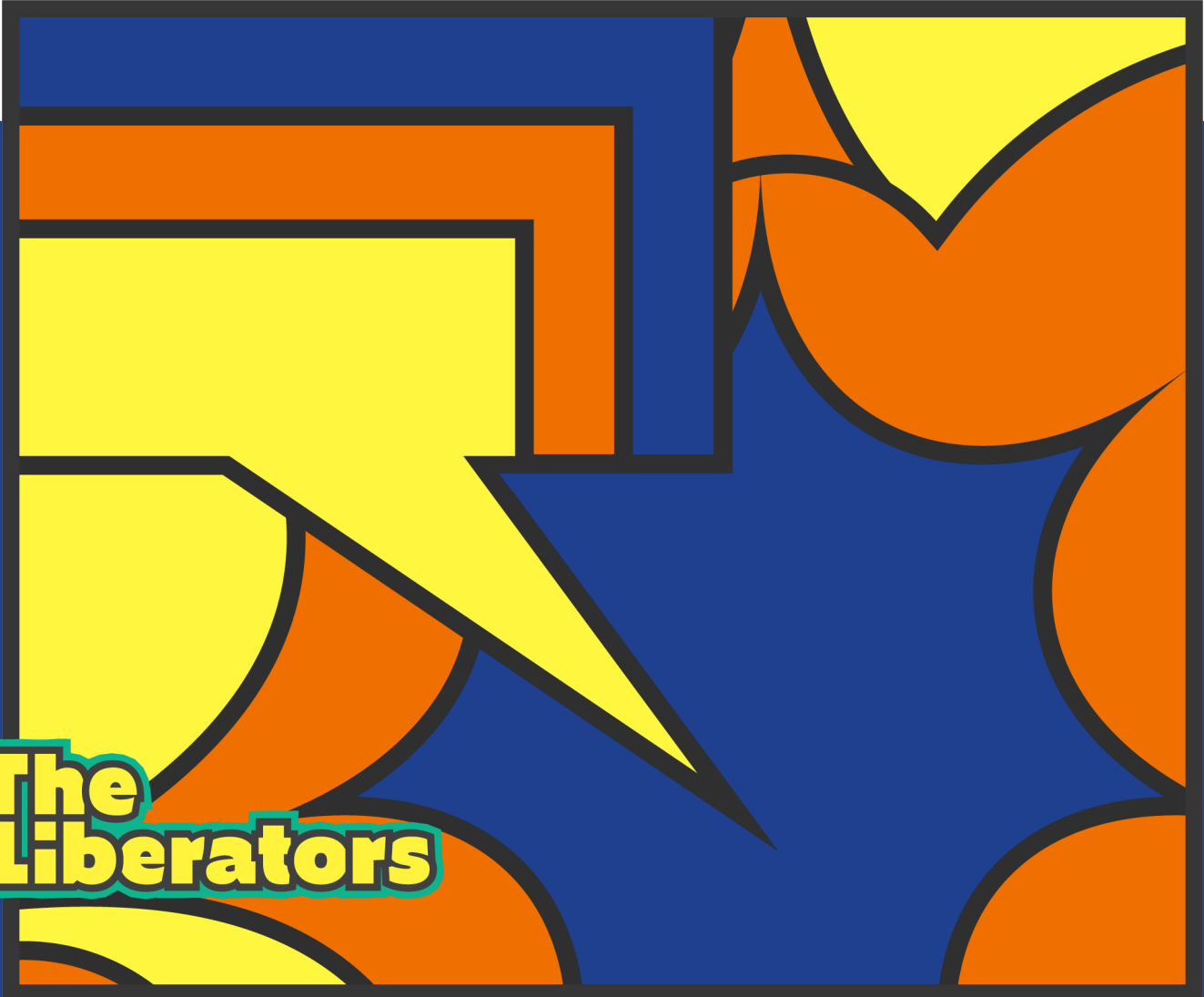


Create An Empathy Map To Articulate Your Customer's Understanding

A simple and powerful experiment that helps Scrum teams to acquire a deep, empathic understanding of the users of their product



**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This Experiment

Hey there!

Building awesome products requires a deep, emphatic understanding of your users. What do they need? What drives them? How do they experience a particular product or process? In this experiment, we explain how to use Empathy Maps and interviews with users to build this understanding.

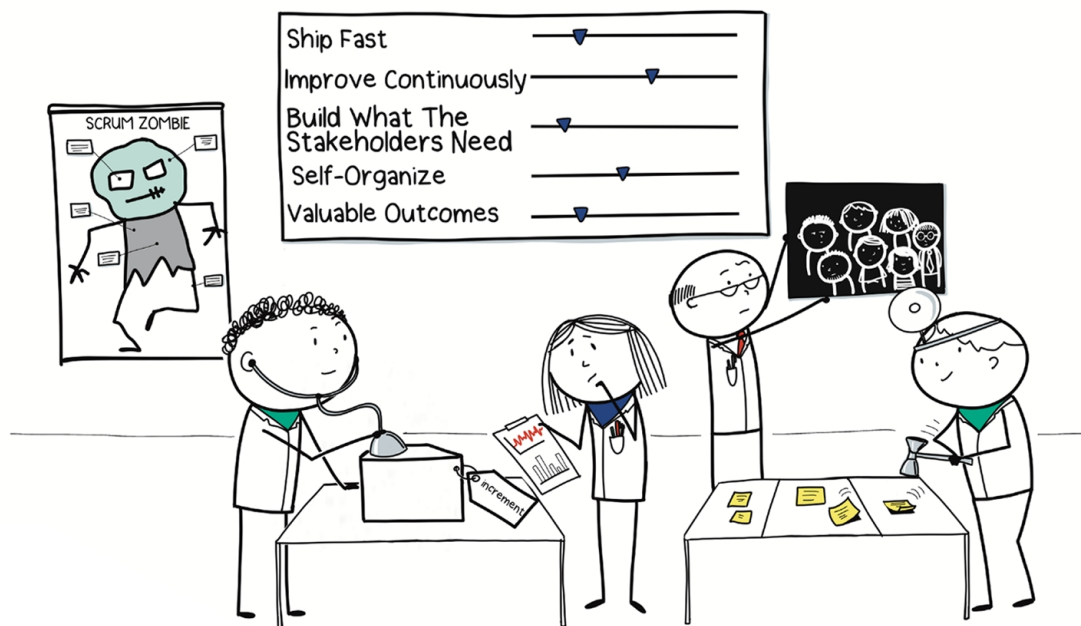
Empathy Maps are a simple, powerful tool to build an understanding of your users. It is no wonder that they are the nuts and bolts of UX designers and are commonly used in Design Thinking. The name derives from 'Empathy', which refers to the ability to understand what another person feels and thinks. A search on Google yields many different templates, but we find the one by [Dave Gray](#) the most practical and complete.

You can create one Empathy Map for all users or multiple maps for different segments or individual users. In any case, the best Empathy Maps are based on real data. Not on conjectures or assumptions that you make as a team. This means that a good Empathy Map requires that we go out there and talk with real users.

Give it a try and let us know how it went!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



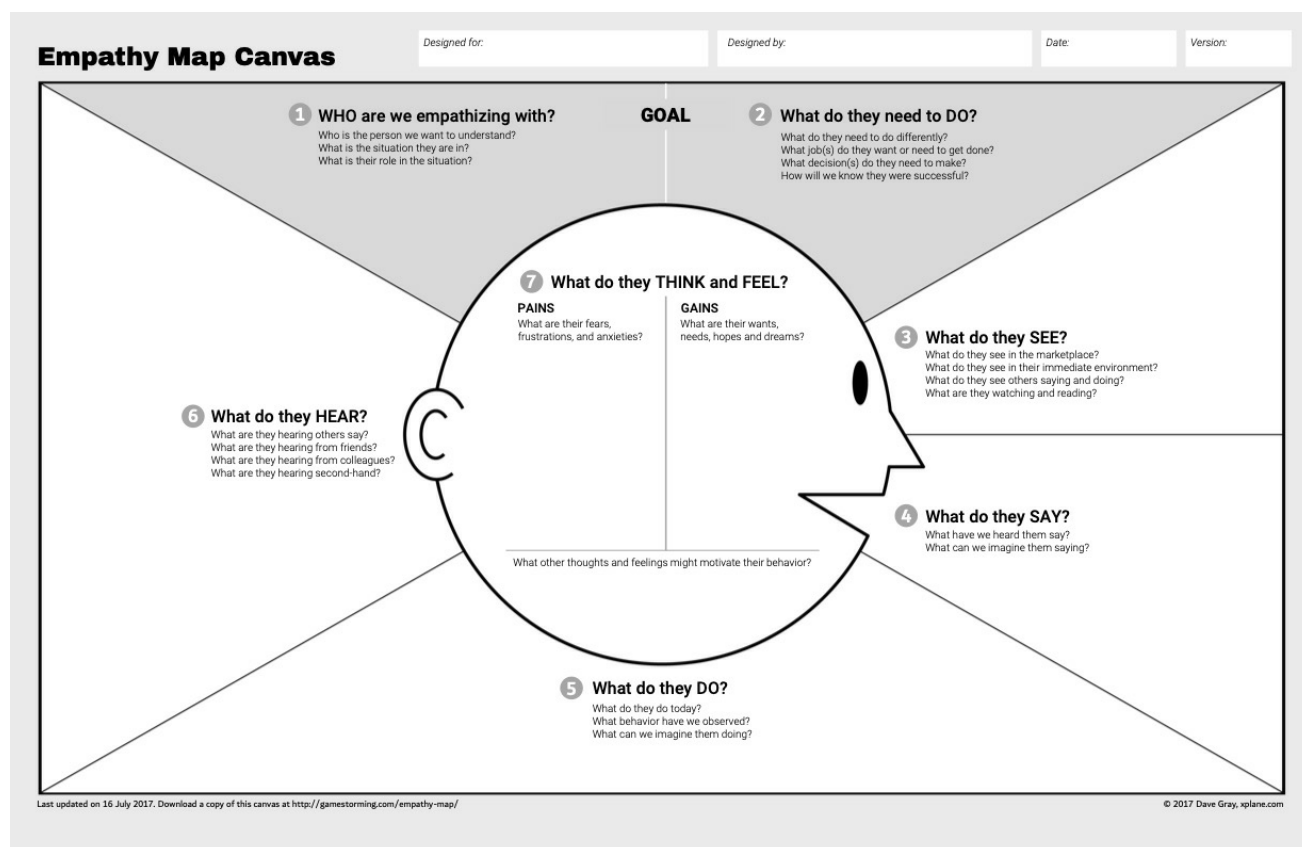
An Empathy Map requires you to go out and talk to real users. This is exciting and scary simultaneously. Make this a team activity, it helps strengthen working as a team.

Impact On Survival



Understanding the behavior and needs of your users are necessary to deliver a product that's considered valuable.





- 5 min** With your (Scrum) team, identify users or customers that you can interview for a period of 30 to 60 minutes. If you interview multiple users, try to find different types of users. Include unhappy users whenever possible. Their perspective often yields intriguing insights;
- 15 min** Prepare the interview with your team. Create a list of open-ended questions that help you understand users. Although we are ultimately interested in building a good product, Empathy Maps are not intended as a way to test product ideas. So focus on the user; what kind of work do they do? What are the challenges they face in their work? What frustrates them? What would they expect from a product? The Empathy Canvas shown in this experiment offers ideas for the kinds of questions that you can ask;
- 15 min** If this is the first time you're going to interview users, it might be beneficial to practice the interviews within your team first. Take turns and practice asking open-ended questions and taking notes at the same time;
- 45 min** Interview the users. You can do this with the team or you can break up into pairs. Make sure that everyone on the team is involved in the process. Take notes during the interview or record it (with permission from the user, obviously);
- 15 min** When you're done conducting the interviews, gather with your team to synthesize the information and extract key insights. Using large printouts of the Empathy Map, write down insights, quotes from users and behaviors on post-its and put them in their corresponding areas of the map;
- 10 min** When you're done creating the maps, reflect on them as a team. What do they tell you? What insights have we gathered? You can either use the maps themselves as input for idea-generation, or you can proceed with other techniques (like brainstorming, visualizing the customer journey, etc);

Our Findings

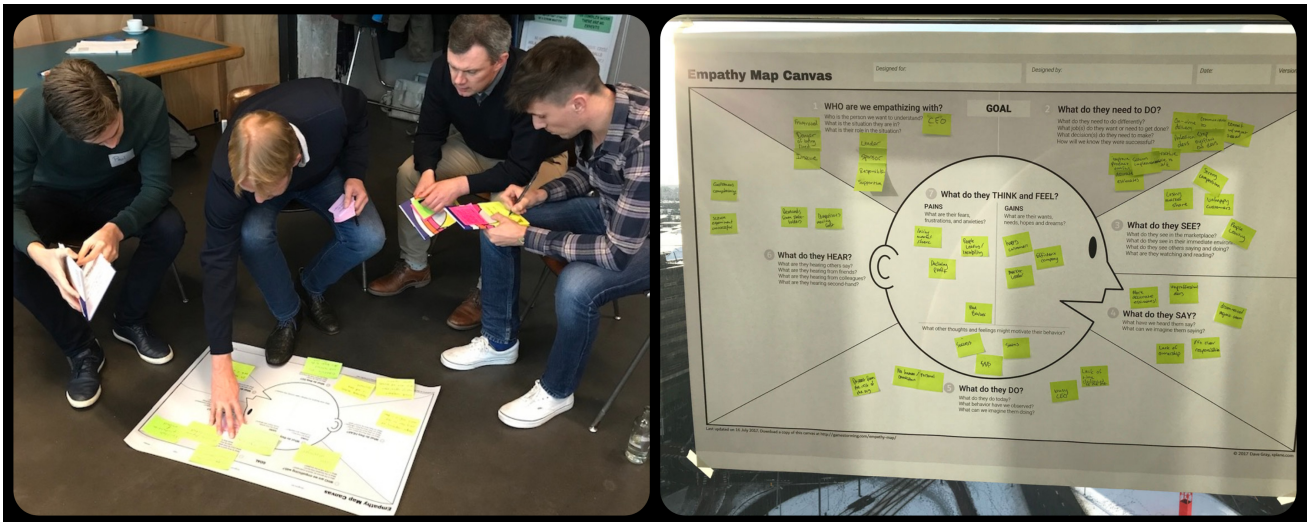
There is no point in creating an Empathy Map that never gets looked at again. Empathy Maps allow us to look at our product through the eyes of our users. This perspective is easily lost as time progresses, making it all the more important to keep the users tangible and visible. Below are a couple of tips:

- Empathy Maps can easily be turned into Personas. A Persona is a fictitious (or sometimes real) user. They describe key traits, behaviors, and expectations. One way to do this is described [here](#);
- Some teams frame their Empathy Maps into picture frames and keep them somewhere visible. We once coached a group of teams who did this. They also created Personas based on real people, and invited these people to (occasionally) attend the Sprint Reviews;
- In the absence of real users, Personas and Empathy Maps are useful during Sprint Planning or Sprint Reviews. Because they make users tangible and visible, they help us to look at our product through their eyes. Would they understand a new feature? Would they like it? What might be frustrating to them?;
- You can also run this exercise virtually. Use a virtual whiteboard like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Often, these tools already have built-in templates to create an Empathy Map.
- Print the Empathy Maps on both a small A4 format and a large poster. Use the A4 format to encourage individual reflection first, and afterward collect all the ideas on the large poster.
- Consider using Liberating Structures like [1-2-4-ALL](#), [Impromptu Networking](#), or [Shift & Share](#) to gather and share ideas.



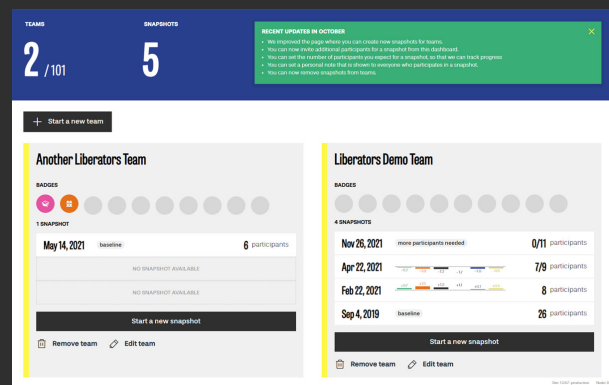
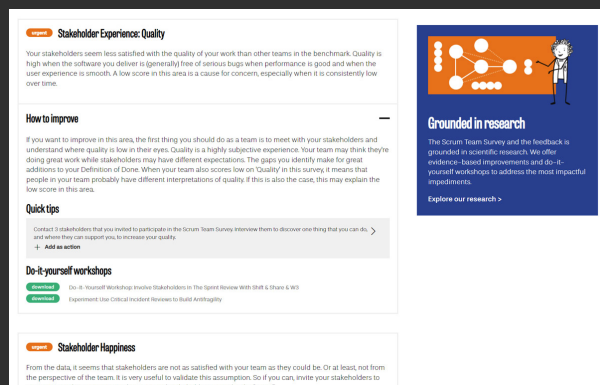
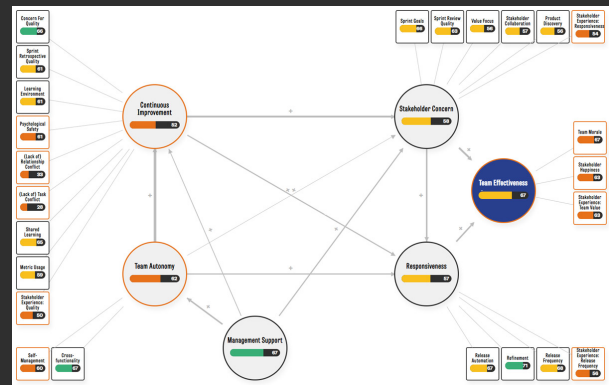
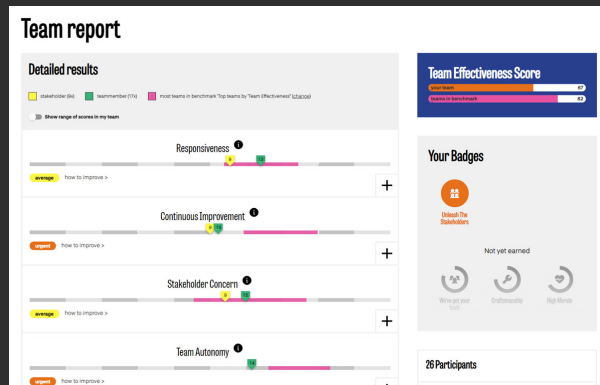
More Resources

- Book: [Gamestorming: A Playbook for Innovators, Rulebreakers, and Changemakers](#) by Dave Gray, Sunni Brown, and James Macanufo
- The original [blog post](#) by Christiaan Verwijs that was used as inspiration for this experiment
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Involve Stakeholders](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)
- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)



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Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

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